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Boldness: How sheer determination, grit, and solitude can help us fly miles into the sky?

I remember the first time in my life I wasn't able to help my friend. One day, my friend was talking to me about her self-help community and how it went on a hiatus during Summer Break. She asked me how to unite her self-help community, especially because of the fact that most of the members of her community were not working on the tasks they were given. Essentially, she was asking me how to become a better leader and motivate her members to continue working on what they established together. Regardless of how long and how deep I thought, I had no answer.

One week ago, her self-help community launched their first event for the current school year, with all the community members. I kept thinking, "How funny it was that when I left her to think for herself, she thought of an idea that was better than the potential solutions I could ever offer her?" It was through this moment that I began to think about how my friend became a better leader by thinking about the scenario she was facing by herself.

Apparently, it is rare for us to take control of the scenarios we are facing by thinking about solutions to the scenarios by ourselves, without our natural dependence on certain people. Yet, when we think through a scenario by ourselves, we often end up creating and finding our best solutions. And if you don't believe me, then read the essay *Solitude and Leadership* by William Deresiewicz. I get the fact that it seems awkward and believe me when I say that I was in your shoes two weeks ago.

When Deresiewicz begins his essay, he states that his "title must seem like a contradiction" (Deresiewicz 11). I was thinking that it was obvious. Why did he need to point it out to us? Then, I thought he was mad. Why would leadership require you to isolate yourself in silence? I mean, these days, most of the leaders we have talk as loudly as all the Bose speakers in the market. They're everywhere! They keep coming on the news, on social media, and into our lives. Our modern definition of leadership is the person who is the loudest in the room, the one with the highest positions, and the person who is the most cunning. What an awkward proposition! While questioning Deresiewicz in the same way I do with my younger brothers, my brain began questioning his purpose: "What was he trying to indicate through his oxymoron? What is his point? What is he trying to prove me into thinking? Why is he making himself look foolish by beginning this way?" It was then I realized that his contradictions were driving me to his point, his purpose, and not anything else. He was not trying to deviate me from his essay, he was making me try to think deeper about his topic. He wanted me to garner all the evidence I have with me to argue against his point. And yet, even the strongest believers will sometimes question their beliefs. He created a doubt in me, a doubt I never had before: "What did solitude have to do with leadership? How does solitude impact our leadership? Is the author really telling us the truth?" His contradiction captivated me. It made me want to read further. It made me want to understand his argument.

Interestingly, Deresiewicz also begins his essay as a conversation. "That's very unusual," I was thinking. What need did he have to strike a conversation with us? Couldn't he have simply

stated his points and left? True, but if he simply stated his points, it would not have resonated with us as deeply. Rather, it would have felt like something we are forced to listen to, something that is not worth our time, something that has no use and no meaning to our lives. We would have simply thought of it as a waste of our time, reminding ourselves and everyone around us that time is a precious resource, something we don't have an infinite quantity of. With his use of pronouns like "we" and "you," he aims to present his understanding of our perspective and decrease his psychic distance. Deresiewicz presents himself as someone who understands what we are thinking about as he begins his essay, instead of aggressively listing all the evidence he could possibly have to support his point. His essay method reminds us that we do not need to think as hard about his topic and what he is about to say. Rather, Deresiewicz is simply asking us to relax and try our best to understand what he is saying, before we make up our minds on what the relationship between solitude and leadership is. In doing so, he makes us want to become open-minded and accepting of other ideas and beliefs, even if we do not exactly believe what he is saying. He motivates us to listen to him, simply by thinking of us, his audience, as people, not obstacles to break down. For the first time in my life, I read his points without starting to annotate every single detail that I disagreed with, all because of the way he explains his point—as a person who understands what we are thinking about when we listen to his points, not as a maniacal person trying to list every single point that he could have to convert us to his beliefs.

All this time, though, I was thinking about Deresiewicz's argument. Deresiewicz pushed me to think about the definition of leadership. It's very common for us to use the word leadership—we keep using it. But, when we are asked to define it, even the most experienced people cannot answer what leadership is to its true integrity. Instead, we can only state our perspectives on what leadership is when we define it. How I am supposed to define leadership when I have no clue what leadership is myself? I am as clueless as an average kindergartener trying to understand the concept of rocket science. I thought that there is no standardized meaning for leadership. Rather, it is a relative word, with no standardized meaning, only what we think of it as.

Yet, Deresiewicz made an attempt to define leadership for us. He begins by stating his background and the institutions and positions we consider while thinking about leadership: "I just spent ten years teaching at an institution that, like West Point, liked to talk about leadership, Yale University....And if not Yale, then Harvard, Stanford, MIT, and so forth. Those institutions, like West Point, see their role as the training of leaders, constantly encourage their students...we find that [the people we consider leaders] come overwhelmingly either from the Ivy League and its peer institutions or from the service academies, especially West Point" (11-12). Deresiewicz points out that these institutions feel the responsibility, or rather, the obligation, to teach their students to become the next leaders of society. But, he begins to question "what leadership really consists of" (12).

At this point, Deresiewicz's writing slowly is slowly appealing to me. His questions were the same questions I asked myself at some point in my life. "What [did] leadership really [consist] of [?]...My students, like you, were smart, energetic, accomplished, and often ferociously ambitious, but did that all make them leaders?...Does being a leader, I wondered, mean being accomplished, being successful? Does getting straight A's make you a 'leader'?" (12). His points were penetrating my mind, creating doubt in what I believed in and made me

feel more welcoming of his argument and the evidences he presented. I mean, did my beliefs help me to find the answers to my questions regarding leadership? Not really, so I sought the thoughts of an author, Deresiewicz. I kept thinking that this dude was understanding everything on my mind. Or, is it that most of us had the same questions and he felt the urge to answer our questions? In either case, these questions made me feel that Deresiewicz had the capacity to understand the thoughts and minds of many, not just of his closest people or his students. I began immersing myself, willingly, into the text. It became my temporary addiction.

Deresiewicz starts his definition of leadership by explaining what he feels leadership is not. He emphasizes how just because someone is great does not mean they are a leader: “A great heart surgeon or a great novelist or a great shortstop may be terrific at what they do, but that doesn’t mean that they’re a leader. Leadership and aptitude, leadership and achievement, leadership and even excellence must be different things, or else the concept of leadership is meaningless” (12). He explains the personalities of the people we often see as leaders during this time:

[They] had trained to be world-class hoop jumpers. Any goal you set them, they could meet. Any test you gave them, they could ace. They were, as one put it, ‘excellent sheep.’ And I had no doubt that they would continue to jump through hoops, and ace tests, and go on to Harvard Business School or Michigan Law School or Johns Hopkins Medical School or Goldman Sachs or McKinsey or wherever. And this approach would take them far in life...And that is exactly what places like Yale have in mind when they talk about leaders. People who make a big name for themselves in the world, people with impressive titles, people whom the university can brag about. People who can climb the greasy pole of whatever hierarchy they decide to attach themselves to. (12-13)

Deresiewicz explains how the institutions that view themselves as the starting point for leaders are educating people who can find the best opportunities and rise in whatever field they want to be a part of.

Yet, the author disagrees with the contemporary definition of leadership. He explains how he believes “that idea is desperately wrong and even dangerous.” He asks, “Why is it so often that the best people are stuck in the middle, while the people who are running things—the leaders—are mediocrities?” (15). Then, he answers, “Because excellence is not what gets you up the greasy pole. What gets you up is a talent for maneuvering. Taking credit for things you didn’t do and shifting blame for things you did. Kissing up to the people above you, kicking down to the people below you. Pleasing your teachers, pleasing your superiors, picking a powerful mentor and riding his coattails until it’s time to stab him in the back. Jumping through hoops. Getting along by going along. Being whatever other people want you to be” (15).

At this point, I was thinking, “Is this the type of people we want as our leaders? Do they not have morals and ethics? Why are they so cunning and manipulative to ensure that capable people are not placed in higher roles? If these are our leaders, then what will end up happening to us? Will they care for us or their company workers at all? Or, are they only here for the title, for the prestige, for the power, for the amount of money they will receive at the end of this all? If this is the case, then when will we get a true leader? Forget that, is it possible that a true leader

exists?” Deresiewicz continues on how he believes that “for too long we have been training leaders who only know how to keep the routine going. Who can answer questions, but don’t know how to ask them. Who can meet goals, but don’t know how to set them. Who think about *how* to get things done, not whether they’re worth doing in the first place...people who have been trained to be incredibly good at one specific thing, but who have no interest in anything beyond their expertise. What we don’t have are leaders. What we don’t have, in other words, are thinkers” (15-16). In doing so, Deresiewicz expresses his disagreement on our current definition of leadership because of the fact that current leaders are not able to do the qualities he finds to be crucial for leaders.

Because Deresiewicz is aware of the fact that many people will not believe him, he expands his points by explaining the failures we have experienced because of the leaders we trained: “We have a crisis in leadership in this country, across every one of our institutions... What happened is that we were stuck...It was the fault of senior leadership, both military and civilian. We were not just not winning: we were not even changing direction” (15). By mentioning how current leadership often has people who are adamant about what they believe is correct, even though their point of view might not always be helpful to current situations, Deresiewicz continues on explaining how leadership as we think of it today is not leadership because of how modern leaders are causing many parts of many institutions to fail since they, for the most part, are not as innovative. In doing so, the entities current leaders lead are not able to find solutions to most, if not all, the problems they have. In my high school, I used to observe each of the administrators, especially our Head of School, our Director of Upper School, and our Dean of Upper School. What I noticed is that many of them take rules and what they believe to be the truth as paramount over anything else. They’re adamant about it, and we can do nothing to change it. In cases where a student or teacher might be in trouble, need support, or have a suggestion to make, they never fully listened to what the student or teacher is saying. They made up their own biases and continued trying to convince people of their points, through a word or two, or through emotional blackmail. And yet, most often, their viewpoints and ideas were not effective for the problems being faced by students, teachers, and other administrators. Their thoughts on how to act on a particular case was not an effective solution for the problem being faced. But, because they did not change their perspectives by maintaining an open-mind, their work, while seemingly solving problems, actually created more problems for the members of my high school to face. Hence, if we continue to be adamant on our thoughts, even though they are not the most effective ways to solve problems, we won’t be able to solve the problems at hand.

But, even though he provides with examples that we experience in our real lives, we also have to remember the fact that he has to appeal to his original audience, students at the U.S. Military Academy, located at West Point and referred to as West Point. Hence, to expand his thoughts on leadership to remain relevant to the students’ lives, which will include a career in the military once they graduate, Deresiewicz includes examples of military leaders who fit his definition of leadership. For example, he expands on a general in the U.S. Army:

Look at the most successful, most acclaimed, and perhaps the finest soldier of his generation, General David Petraeus. He is one of those rare people who rises through a bureaucracy for the right reasons. He is a thinker. He is an intellectual...what makes him

a thinker—and a leader—is precisely his ability to think things through for himself. And because of that ability, he also has the confidence, the courage, to advocate for his ideas even when they are unpopular. Even when they do not please his superiors...It wasn't always easy for him...He was way ahead of the leadership in Baghdad and Washington, and bureaucracies don't like that sort of thing. Here he was, just another two-star, and he was saying, implicitly but loudly, that the leadership was wrong about the way it was running the war. Indeed, he wasn't rewarded at first. Quite the contrary: he was shunted to a dead-end job, put in charge of training the Iraqi Army, a major blow to his career. But he stuck to his beliefs, and he was ultimately vindicated. (17)

By mentioning the example of General David Petraeus, Deresiewicz, ultimately, indicates how through skills for true leadership, such as being a thinker and thinking things through deeply, people—even if they challenge their authorities or precedents—will be able to rise once again and become leaders without manipulating scenarios and grabbing appropriate opportunities to earn a leadership position. In most cases, the people in our environment will not appreciate us standing up for ourselves and our thoughts. But, when we do, they might see you as a threat for challenging them. They might try every way possible to make sure that our thoughts do not gain popularity. And yet, it is because of our unconventional thought process that we receive appreciation. The people in our environment will begin to understand how wrong they were and suddenly become more accepting of us and our thoughts. In doing so, our thoughts will be accepted and respected and we will emerge victorious.

After explaining how our current definition is not sufficient for the needs of our modern world, Deresiewicz completes his definition of leadership by mentioning how capable leaders need “to be able to think independently, creatively, and flexibly” and that “true leadership means being able to think for yourself and act on your convictions” (16-17). By explicitly stating his definition of leadership, Deresiewicz explains what we need to understand about the concept of leadership, before continuing onwards. Leadership requires us to be bold and unafraid of what will happen because of our willingness to act on our thoughts. Take a look at our contemporary leaders, like Steve Jobs, Mark Zuckerberg, Larry Page, and Sergey Brin. Each of them took steps that were quite contrary to the actions most Americans were taking. While creating their respective companies, they needed to think openly and without doubt on their thoughts to get to the point their companies are at today. They were willing to take a risk and go beyond the limitations we have set up for ourselves, as a society, thus allowing them to become profitable and innovative. Without these traits, our contemporary leaders, the leaders we look up to as our role models, would not have been at the stage they are at today. Instead, they too, might have become CEOs of companies with lower profits or companies on the verge of bankruptcy, like General Motors. However, because of their drive to try something that no one else has tried, they were able to make their ideas become a reality, and create companies that have impacted and changed the state of humanity in a significant way.

Now, Deresiewicz begins to define solitude. But, how could he do so without an anecdote? If he didn't do so, he would falter on his connection with his audience, wouldn't he? He begins with an anecdote regarding his students: “Students would sometimes brag to me about how fast they wrote their papers. I would tell them that Thomas Mann, the great German

novelist, remarked that a writer is someone for whom writing is more difficult than it is for other people. The best writers write more slowly, not more quickly, than everyone else, and the better they are, the slower they write” (18). Through this anecdote, Deresiewicz tries to connect his students’ actions to the words of a famous novelist, Thomas Mann. In doing so, he provides one example of solitude in the context of writing. Afterwards, he defines solitude: “Concentrating, focusing. Instead of solitude, you could easily consider this lecture to be about concentration. Think about the meaning of the word. It means gathering yourself together into a single point rather than letting yourself be dispersed into a cloud of electronic and social input” (19). By defining what solitude is, Deresiewicz allows his audience to establish a foundation on what they believe solitude is, if they do not have a definition of solitude already, as well as to provide readers with their own perspective on solitude to understand what he means when he discusses solitude.

By defining his definition of leadership and solitude, Deresiewicz takes us on a journey through his mind and thought processes. In doing so, he accompanies us through his essay by establishing what exactly he intends to talk about with his audience. Because of his way of communicating with us through his text, Deresiewicz ensures that he is able to answer the questions readers have and ensures that he stays with us until his message and thoughts permeate into our minds. He never leaves us, allowing us to understand each part of the essay, even if we aren’t the intended audience. In doing so, he appeals to us because of his ability to stay connected with us, especially when parts of his essay become more relative and abstract.

Afterwards, Deresiewicz describes the various types of solitude:

So solitude can involve introspection, it can involve the concentration of focused work, and it can involve sustained reading. All of these help you to know yourself better. But there is one more form of solitude that I will list, and it will seem counterintuitive: friendship...But I’m referring to one sort of friendship in particular: the deep friendship of intimate conversation. Long, uninterrupted talk with one other person. Not Skyping with three other people and texting with two more while you hang out in a friend’s room studying and listening to music. Introspection means talking to yourself, and one of the best ways to talk to yourself is by talking to someone else. Someone you can trust, someone to whom you can unfold your soul. Someone with whom you feel safe enough to acknowledge things—to acknowledge things to yourself—that you otherwise can’t. (22)

I see another contradiction. And yet, something about the contradiction between friendship and solitude feels familiar. Whenever I talk with my closest friends, such as my friend who has a self-help community, I feel like I can process my thoughts and explain the logic necessary to solve a problem that I am facing. I don’t know why, but it feels like the presence of my closest friends allows me to view anything through another perspective, allowing me to wrap my head around something I was struggling in before I met my friend. I guess, in that sense, our closest friends allow us to make sense of ourselves, make sense of whatever is puzzling us, make sense of the scenarios we are facing. In doing so, we are able to think things through in a calmer, more informal way, allowing us to become more confident in what we have come up with along the

way. While I reread this passage, I realized that the author used humor. He states, “Not Skyping with three other people and texting with two more while you hang out in a friend’s room studying and listening to music” (22). How many of us can relate to this, (barring the fact that Skype was removed in May 2025, so we can’t use Skype anymore)? In our current world, these types of scenarios are common. In many cases, even if we are meeting with a friend, we keep multitasking on various levels, thus obstructing us from having a deep conversation with the friend we are face-to-face with. In doing so, we steadily lose opportunities to strengthen our friendships such that we can use them to help us face our scenarios by finding effective solutions.

While discussing about solitude, Deresiewicz includes an allusion to the American Revolution and connects it to the concept of solitude. He states, “And when I say ‘revolutionary,’ I am deliberately evoking the American Revolution, which resulted precisely from this kind of independent thinking. Without solitude—the solitude of Adams and Jefferson and Hamilton and Madison and Paine—there would be no United States” (22). By mentioning how one such result of solitude includes the establishment of the United States, Deresiewicz does not only explain that solitude allows us to do something life-changing and big, but he also appeals to his original audience because of the fact that they will become a part of the U.S. military, an entity established only after the establishment of the United States. Personally, I agree with Deresiewicz’s point. Before the time of the American Revolution, Europe, and the American colonies as a result, were experiencing the Renaissance and the Enlightenment, as well as its impacts on philosophy, governments, and economics. During the pre-American Revolution days, men would come together and discuss their own thoughts and the thoughts they had on others’ work. Eventually, these discussions became the foundation for men trying to understand how to apply their thoughts into reality. For example, John Locke came up with the ideas of natural rights and the social contract. And the thinkers, philosophers, and other people who respected and admired the work first think about it thoroughly. They used solitude to their advantage while trying to understand the thoughts and works of notable authors of the time. They immersed themselves in the ideas of the authors of the time. In the case of the American Revolution, colonists started to reflect and agree upon the ideas of government and their operations that contemporary authors believed in. They came to understand that these ideas of government that the American colonists, for the majority part, had agreed upon were usually not present in the operations of the British government in colonial America. The colonists disagreed with the way the British government was running colonial America. And, in doing so, through the understanding they gained as a result of their solitude, many of the American colonists declared independence from the British government, using the philosophies they acquired through their solitude as the basis and foundational reasons for their cause. In short, it was through their solitude that the leaders of the American Revolution began the Revolution as a way to fight for the government that they believed would give them equal rights and liberties, as well as promote the causes and policies that the people demand.

Later on, Deresiewicz discusses how solitude would not be easy for his intended audience because of the fact that soldiers share multiple, if not all, spaces together. Furthermore, because of the fact that soldiers in the Army usually do their activities—both basic and not—and their work together, they will definitely not find enough time alone. But, he emphasizes that solitude is necessary to allow them to make tough decisions, such as when the intended audience’s

“superiors [are] condoning conduct that [they] think is wrong?...The[r]e are truly formidable dilemmas, more so than most of us ever face...The time to start preparing for them is now. And the way to do so is by thinking through these issues for yourself...so that you will be equipped to deal with them when they arise”(23). By explaining the usage of solitude in the lives of the intended audience, Deresiewicz makes it seem more imperative that his audience adopt the practice of accessing solitude as a way to think through the scenario they are facing and create effective, possibly even innovative, solutions. In life, we will experience situations where we only have access to our own thoughts. The situations will depend on our thoughts and how they translate into reality. Yet, it is these situations that require more thinking and effective solutions. These situations are difficult, maybe even both physically and mentally. But, when we begin using solitude, we think through the constraints and potential obstacles or faults in the situations. We then think through how we can create a solution with the present limitations. Afterwards, we test our proposed solutions, if possible. Last but not least, we choose the solution that we believe will work the best for our situation. In short, solitude allows us to think through the entire situation to find potential solutions. Without accessing solitude, we wouldn't be able to find a solution that solely addresses the problem; rather, it addresses other people's points of view on the situation.

In the end, Deresiewicz explains how solitude is important for the lives of his audience because of how it allows us to think through whatever we are facing and face them by creating some of the best solutions we can to pass and go beyond whatever we are facing. In doing so, Deresiewicz ensures that he kickstarts our own thoughts on adopting and using solitude in the parts of our lives where it will become necessary to use. He begins our process of self-improvement by explaining how solitude and leadership connect to our personal, academic, and professional lives. And that makes the difference between whether he was another writer who writes what they feel or if he was an author that was interested in bettering the lives of people by teaching them how to become better, innovative, capable people who can face any scenario.

My friend began using her free-time to simply think about her self-community and what she would do to increase member engagement. She began asking around and researching for methods to increase member engagement, whether it may be organizing an event or hosting workshops for teenagers on their self-identity. She used her solitude to contemplate and reflect on the situation. One random day, she found her solution. She found how to get her members to work on the tasks for the communities: major events. With major events, she realized her members will have an increased interest in the community as they are now able to express their thoughts and how to help one another and themselves become better people. Without thinking about what other people, except her closest friends, might feel, my friend began adopting methods to increase member engagement. She didn't care whether they might take too much work or not; she used her motivation and her deeper understanding from her solitude to continue forward. She used her solitude to solve her problem by herself, without the need of her friends.

Now, I know what to tell people when they ask me for leadership advice: “Think. Think hard. Think more than you've thought before. Don't worry about expectations. Don't worry about what people want you to do. Stay true to your own values, what you believe is correct. Follow through on your thoughts. Don't be scared. Don't limit yourself because you've had enough of limitations. You've been boxed off for far too long. Be bold and be unique. Show who

you are to the rest of the world. And, yes, they will talk about you. They might make fun of you, but, one day, they will appreciate you for your daring. For your innovativeness. For your willingness to go beyond what you have before. Put your best foot forward, and simply enjoy the ride."

Work Cited

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